

THE NEW SCHOOL • EUGENE LANG COLLEGE OF LIBERAL ARTS

Assignment 0: Find Some Useful Data

LMTH 2080 — Data and Design with Python

Due Monday, September 14, 2026

Eugene Lang College of Liberal Arts

Key Idea

Start with something you want to understand, not with a dataset or a programming tool.

problem → **question** → **evidence** → **data**

The Assignment

Identify a problem or question that genuinely interests you and find **two plausible sources of data** that could help you investigate it.

Your question can be large or small. The important thing is that you begin with a question you care about and then ask what evidence would actually help you investigate it.

Data Question

What problem or question are you interested in?

Write this before you begin searching for data. You may revise the question after seeing what data is actually available.

Find Two Data Sources

Find two different data sources that could plausibly provide evidence related to your question. A useful source might be a downloadable CSV or spreadsheet, a government open-data portal, a public API, data published by a research organization, an archive, or another source that gives you access to the underlying observations.

An article, chart, dashboard, or report may help you *find* data, but it is not automatically the data itself. Whenever possible, locate the underlying dataset.

Investigate Each Source

For **each** source, answer:

1. Where does the data come from?
2. Who produced or collected it?

3. What does one observation or row represent?
4. What are several important variables?
5. What could this data help you understand about your question?
6. What is missing, uncertain, or limited about the data?

Design Question

Imagine someone wanted to use this data to make a decision. What would you want them to understand about where the data came from and what it fails to capture?

Choose

Choose the source that seems more useful for your question and explain why. Your choice does not have to be the larger, cleaner, or more sophisticated dataset. A small dataset that closely matches your question may be more useful than a massive dataset that does not.

If possible, download the data you choose and inspect the actual file.

Create Your README

Create a file named README.md using this structure:

```
# Useful Data
```

```
## Question
```

What problem or question are you interested in?

```
## Data Source 1
```

```
**Source:**
```

```
**Produced by:**
```

```
**What does one row represent?**
```

```
**Important variables:**
```

```
### What could this data help you understand?
```

```
### What is missing or limited about this data?
```

```
## Data Source 2
```

```
**Source:**
```

```
**Produced by:**
```

```
**What does one row represent?**
```

```
**Important variables:**
```

What could this data help you understand?

What is missing or limited about this data?

My Choice

Which dataset seems more useful for your question, and why?

You may write informally, but your README should make it possible for someone else to understand what you found and why you think it could be useful.

Include the Data When Reasonable

If your chosen dataset is a reasonably sized downloadable file, include it in your project directory.

```
assignment00/  
|-- README.md  
'-- data/  
    '-- my_data.csv
```

Checkpoint

Do not put a huge dataset in your Git repository.

If the data is very large, generated dynamically, accessed through an API, or cannot reasonably be included, provide a clear link to the source in your README instead. If useful, you may include a small sample.

Record Your Work with Git

Begin by asking what has changed:

```
git status
```

Stage your README:

```
git add README.md
```

If you are including a small data file, stage that file as well. Then record the version:

```
git commit -m "Complete useful data investigation"
```

Finally:

```
git status
```

Your instructor will provide any additional GitHub submission instructions.

Generative AI

For this assignment, **do not use generative AI to choose your question, locate your datasets, or evaluate whether the data is useful.**

The searching, inspecting, comparing, and deciding are the work of this assignment. You may use ordinary web search, documentation, data portals, course materials, and help from the instructor.

What to Submit

By the beginning of class on **Monday, September 14**, you should have:

- a question or problem you want to investigate;
- two plausible data sources;
- a completed README.md;
- a clear explanation of which source you chose and why;
- the chosen data or a link to it, as appropriate; and
- at least one Git commit recording your work.

Reflection

Is this data useful for what I am actually trying to understand?